Use-Within Cheat Chart

hang inside a cabinet door · guidance, not gospel

Pantry

COOL, DARK, SEALED

Canned goods (high-acid: tomatoes)	12–18 mo
Canned goods (low-acid: beans, veg)	2–5 yr
Dried pasta, rice (white)	2 yr
Whole grains (brown rice, oats)	6–12 mo
Flour, all-purpose	8–12 mo
Whole-wheat flour	3–6 mo
Opened cooking oil	4–6 mo
Vinegar, honey, sugar, salt	years
Spices, whole	2–4 yr
Spices, ground + blends	6–12 mo
Dried beans	1–2 yr
Baking powder / soda	6–12 mo

Fridge

AT 40°F OR BELOW

Raw ground meat or poultry	1–2 days
Raw steaks, chops, roasts	3–5 days
Raw fish and shellfish	1–2 days
Cooked meat and leftovers	3–4 days
Eggs, in the carton	3–5 wk
Opened milk	~1 wk
Yogurt, opened	1–2 wk
Hard cheese, opened	3–6 wk
Soft cheese, opened	1–2 wk
Opened deli meat	3–5 days
Chicken or veg stock, opened	3–4 days
Wilted greens	immediate sauté

Freezer

AT 0°F — SAFE INDEFINITELY; BELOW IS QUALITY

Cooked soups, stews, chili	3–4 mo
Cooked casseroles, lasagna	2–3 mo
Raw ground meat	3–4 mo
Raw steaks and roasts	4–12 mo
Raw chicken pieces	9 mo
Cooked meatballs, taco beef	3 mo
Bread, bagels, muffins	3 mo
Cookie dough, balls	2–3 mo
Fruit, sliced and frozen	8–12 mo
Veggies, blanched	8–12 mo
Stock in jars or bags	4–6 mo
Butter, well wrapped	6–9 mo

How to use it: write the "date out" on every freezer label as the date in here *plus* this window — the math happens once, while the food goes in. **When in doubt:** look, smell, then toss. Freezer-burned food is safe; smelly fridge food is not. **This chart is friendly education, not a safety certification;** your local extension office and the date printed on packaging always win.

Weekly

Scan the fridge shelf on trash night; anything 3+ days old becomes lunch or goes to the freezer.

Monthly

Freezer amnesty day: pull everything forward, re-date anything missing a "date out" label.

Seasonally

Check spice jars against this chart; send faded ones to "soup builder" duty — strong smell only matters when it has faded.